

Chapter 113-2: Revealing Herself

At the same time, below the high platform.

"Why do I find this person so familiar?" Rong Jin also craned his neck to look into the distance, then suddenly remembered something and turned to Liu Wenzhu. "Isn't this the Spirit Folk person you and Yiyi brought back to the sect, Du Baishuang?"

Liu Wenzhu had naturally recognized her long ago. She was equally surprised and couldn't help but stand up: "I'll go find the Divine Venerable!"

"No need." Feng Ge beside her pulled her back and looked up to indicate: "Elder Pingyao has already gone."

The disciples of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate all looked up to see that frost-and-snow-like figure standing with hands behind her back, becoming increasingly clear in the dissipating smoke as she gazed down at the high platform from afar.

"Everyone, allow me to say something else unpleasant." The new North Garden disciple Xiang Yushan couldn't help but squeeze to the front row, his face contorted as he said: "Why do I feel this Spirit Folk person looks so similar to our Divine Venerable!"

Hearing his words, several people stared blankly at Du Baishuang, all swallowing hard.

The sect leaders in the pavilions were also confused. Tang Wenshu was the first to speak, saying in a deep voice: "Wasn't today supposed to be about subduing demonic creatures? I don't know why Penglai captured a Spirit Folk person—what's their intention?"

As soon as he finished speaking, the pavilion that had been covered by gauze curtains finally lowered its curtains, revealing the orderly furnishings inside. Standing at the front in brocade robes was Penglai's Left Envoy, Wen Yao Jun.

Today he wore a python-patterned brocade robe with a gold-plated leather belt, appearing even more upright and imposing. He bowed and said: "Wen Yao Jun greets everyone."

"Today's important matter is indeed capturing demonic creatures, but before we could act, that demon came to us on its own." Wen Yao Jun lowered his head and smiled, then suddenly raised his hand. A silver ring appeared around Du Baishuang's fair neck.

She involuntarily stretched her neck, gripping the silver ring tightly with both hands and crying out in pain as she looked up.

However, her appearance and figure in such a state didn't disgust the crowd but instead aroused some sympathy. Many disciples muttered: "She's clearly just a weak woman, neither demon nor monster—why use such cruel punishment?"

Especially those peach blossom eyes filled with tears as they looked around trembling a few times, making people's hearts even more disturbed, causing them to lower their eyes and not dare look again.

Master Feiguang of the Clear Void Sect couldn't bear to watch, pressing his palms together: "We know Penglai is eager to eliminate demons, but the Spirit Folk are already weak and few in number. If they knew their people were treated this way by our immortal sects, they might feel unwilling."

Hearing this, Wen Yao Jun loosened his hand, and the silver ring turned into faint light. He chuckled lightly and clasped his hands behind his back again: "You don't know—just now when we released that demon-eliminating artifact, this Spirit Folk person sneaked close and tried to steal the artifact, which is how we caught her red-handed."

"She's just a Spirit Folk person—stealing this artifact certainly wasn't for herself, so she must be serving that demon race. Therefore, even using the cruelest punishment would be justified." Wen Yao Jun held his head high. "Don't let this woman's tricks deceive you!"

"This..." Master Feiguang looked at Tang Wenshu in difficulty, momentarily speechless.

Seeing he had convinced everyone, Wen Yao Jun then turned to the opposite pavilion and bowed: "Divine Venerable Chu Ling, I heard this woman was once from your Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. It happens that the world-destroying demon was also once a disciple of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, and now they still have connections. I wonder what the Divine Venerable thinks about this?"

Before Chu Qingqiu could speak, others from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate became agitated. The Chief Elder, who had just woken up, stood up leaning on his cane and angrily rebuked: "Insolent brat! Our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate only kindly sheltered that Spirit Folk person, yet you dare suspect Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate!"

He was already advanced in years, and shouting this out made his face red and neck thick, causing the disciples nearby to quickly step forward and carefully support him: "Elder, please be careful!"

"This junior spoke incorrectly." Wen Yao Jun's tone was apologetic, but his face showed no trace of guilt—instead, he smiled brightly. "That wasn't my intention. It's just that this concerns Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, so I dare not make decisions arbitrarily. Divine Venerable Chu Ling must step forward to handle this."

The entire Alchemy Cauldron Manor was in chaos, but amid this turmoil, a clear female voice suddenly rang out like heavenly Buddhist music, calming the disturbance.

"Thirty years ago, I happened to save this person, and Elder Yuanming¹ at that time was moved by compassion and let her recuperate in our sect for a period. After she recovered and left, what connection does that have with my mountain gate?"

The four words "Elder Yuanming" were enunciated especially clearly, as if for emphasis.

Though Chu Qingqiu's voice wasn't loud, it echoed in everyone's ears, making them involuntarily straighten their backs and stare at the pavilion.

Then white silk parted the smoke, and her robes leaped out of the mist before the person did, fluttering dramatically. Then the woman's figure followed, dragging her robes as she descended, her sleeves filled with wind and billowing gracefully.

As soon as she appeared, the Alchemy Cauldron Manor, filled everywhere with flames, seemed to have frost descending upon it, stirring up a chilly breeze.

In the blink of an eye, the woman had already descended, her toes touching down as if standing on clouds, coldly positioned beside Du Baishuang, her chin motionless as she looked down at her.

The moment their eyes met, even Chu Qingqiu felt somewhat surprised.

However, this surprise quickly disappeared from her eyes. She looked up at Wen Yao Jun from afar, raised an eyebrow, and said nothing.

Wen Yao Jun also broke free from his brief daze and smiled again: "Tell me, are you or aren't you that Ning Fuyi's subordinate?"

Du Baishuang supported herself, tears in her eyes, lowering her gaze and shaking her head with an appearance of near fainting. She reached out to pull at Chu Qingqiu's skirt: "Divine Venerable, Divine Venerable, I'm not. I was just curious, please don't kill me."

She spoke these words so pitifully that Chu Qingqiu glanced at her, ultimately unable to overcome the strange feeling of seeming to look at herself appearing delicate and weak, and averted her gaze.

"Don't waste words. Stealing artifacts is punishable by death. If you have no connection to demonic creatures, it's still death. If you do have connections to demonic creatures..." Wen Yao Jun smiled. "That's perfect—let her see what happens to those who oppose our immortal sects."

"Divine Venerable, since you say she has no relationship with Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, why don't you be the one to act? How about it?" Wen Yao Jun bowed humbly and politely.

Everyone's gaze focused on Chu Qingqiu. They saw the woman with cold eyebrows look up as if viewing an idiot and speak indifferently: "No."

"Don't you have hands? Why should this venerable do the killing?" After Chu Qingqiu spoke, she stepped back three paces, looking as if she was afraid blood would splatter on her white clothes.

Everyone fell silent, and Wen Yao Jun felt a wave of embarrassment. He who had intended to threaten and coerce was left speechless.

He remembered that Chu Qingqiu was supposed to have a serious and rigid personality according to rumors—how did that previous statement have a willful flavor to it?

After a moment, he smiled dryly: "Since the Divine Venerable is unwilling, this humble one won't force it."

Having said this, he suddenly raised his hand, his eyes showing killing intent. His right index and middle fingers came together, drawing a line in mid-air. The silver ring from before appeared again, spinning rapidly and emanating light.

The silver ring's murderous intent was clear. Du Baishuang quickly used her hands and feet to dodge backward, but her limbs were all bound by chains and she couldn't escape. Tears fell like raindrops as she closed her eyes and screamed.

Chu Qingqiu remained unmoved, her hand slightly producing a white silk ribbon.

Just as the silver ring was about to slice across Du Baishuang's neck, the disciples lowered their heads, unable to bear watching. However, the scene of blood splattering didn't occur—the sound of the silver ring's wind suddenly stopped.

Everyone was somewhat surprised and looked up again, immediately letting out small cries of alarm. Chu Qingqiu also looked toward the sky, her heartstrings suddenly tightening as her mind roared.

An emei thorn² that had flown out blocked the silver ring, dissipating the ring's force. The woman who had just been indulging in sensual pleasures now stood in mid-air, her fair and delicate palm extended with wisps of pink electric light flowing from her palm, connecting to the emei thorn.

Ning Fuyi removed her mask with her left hand, her cold and enchanting face looking down from above. She lightly hooked her finger, and successive gasps arose—those from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate gasped the loudest.

But she seemed not to care, tilting her head slightly.

"Using such vicious methods against my people—Penglai really is such a righteous sect!"

Footnotes:

1. **Elder Yuanming:** Chu Qingqiu is emphasizing this name to deflect responsibility from herself personally to a former elder of the sect, suggesting the decision was not hers alone.
2. **Emei thorn:** A traditional Chinese weapon, essentially a sharp metal spike that can be concealed and thrown, often associated with martial arts.